RWANDA

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Prepared by Africa INSIGHTS Research Team | Vertical: Travel & Tourism

Rwanda holds a strong perception score of 70 on the back of world-class scenery and hospitality, but a multi-year score drift demands urgent attention on cost and food.

1,526	70%	15%	15%	70/100
RECORDS IN VIEW	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	PERCEPTION

01 MONTH IN REVIEW

Rwanda enters the close of this reporting period — February 2015 to June 2026 — with a **perception score of 70 out of 100** and a **net sentiment of 54.3**, a position that places it among the upper tier of African destinations and well ahead of the peer-group median. The headline story is one of earned strength: scenery and hospitality dominate the conversation and are overwhelmingly positive, anchoring a market reputation that is structurally sound. Yet the period hides a slow erosion that the headline score obscures — from a peak of **79 in 2018**, the score has slid to **66 in 2026**, with cost negativity worsening measurably and food negativity following the same trajectory.

The single most urgent action is to address the cost perception problem before it migrates into the broader narrative. Cost is the one reportable theme whose negativity has demonstrably worsened across the period, and it sits at a net sentiment low enough to weaken Rwanda's value case precisely when gorilla-permit pricing and premium lodge positioning are most prominent in international media.

The good news is structural: safety sentiment has undergone a dramatic improvement within the period and Rwanda leads its peer group on that dimension by a substantial margin — an advantage that remains underleveraged in destination marketing. Any campaign refresh should lead with safety and double down on scenery while treating cost transparency as a trust-building, not a defensive, communication.

DATA NOTE
The trend series runs to 2026, but the period_end is June 2026, meaning the 2026 data point represents a partial year. Volume for 2026 is the highest on record at 263 records, so the sample is sound, but year-on-year comparisons with full prior years should be read cautiously.

DATA NOTE
Year-level granularity prevents identification of within-year seasonal shifts.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

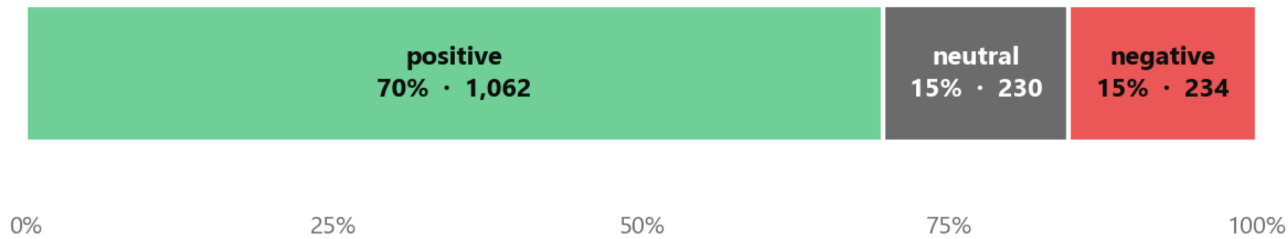
Rwanda's **perception score of 70** sits on a scale where 50 represents neutrality, placing the destination clearly in positive territory. The **net sentiment of 54.3** confirms that positive voices substantially outnumber negative ones — **69.6% of records are positive**, **15.1% neutral**, and **15.3% negative**. The near-symmetry between the neutral and negative shares is the most diagnostic feature of this distribution: Rwanda is not a polarised destination generating fierce critics alongside fierce advocates. Instead, it holds a large, stable positive majority with a modest and roughly equal fringe of undecideds and detractors.

That shape implies a market with strong baseline credibility but limited urgency among the unconverted. A destination with **15.1%** neutrals is one where a meaningful portion of observers are watching but not yet persuaded — the job of marketing is to tip this group, not merely preach to an existing base. The **15.3%** negative share, while manageable in absolute terms, is large enough to register in composite scores and is concentrated in specific themes — cost, safety, and food — rather than spread evenly, which makes it addressable.

The emotional texture of the corpus reinforces this reading. **Excited** is the dominant detected emotion at **26.4% of records**, with **longing** the second-largest at **8.7%** — together these suggest a destination that stirs genuine aspiration. **Fearful** and **disappointed** responses are each present in only **1.0%** of records, a very low floor that confirms the negative share is driven by practical friction rather than deep reputational damage. The implication for messaging is clear: emotional pull is already working; the task is removing the practical barriers that prevent it from converting.

DATA NOTE
Emotion data are available only in aggregate; it is not possible from this pack to disaggregate emotions by theme or segment.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown
How the 1,526 records in view split across sentiment classes. Net sentiment is +54 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is the dominant engine of Rwanda's positive perception, with **356 mentions**, a **positive rate of 89.3%**, and a net sentiment of **82.3** — the highest of any reportable theme. The near-absence of negativity in this category (just **7.0%**) means Rwanda's landscapes, volcanoes, and rainforest canopy are effectively uncontested in global conversation. This is a rare asset: a product feature that functions as a universal point of agreement across travel types and nationalities. Campaigns and itinerary design that keep scenery visually central are working with the grain of organic public opinion.

Hospitality is the second pillar, drawing **176 mentions** and a net sentiment of **52.3**, though the negative share here — **20.5%** — is more elevated than scenery and worth monitoring. The warmth of reception is genuine and widely cited, but a fifth of hospitality mentions carry criticism, suggesting variability in service delivery below the headline experience. Rwanda leads its peer group on hospitality by a gap of **32.1 points** against the peer net of **20.2**, which means this advantage is real and differentiating — but must not be treated as guaranteed. **Food** sits at a net of **44.6** across **56 mentions** and is reportable; it contributes positively to the overall picture but its negativity share has worsened across the period, a dynamic addressed further in the trends section.

Safety is the most striking thematic story of the full period. With a net of **28.6** across **35 mentions**, it registers positive overall — and the within-period movement has been dramatic, with negative safety mentions falling from **62.5%** in the first half of the period to **10.5%** in the second. This is among the largest sentiment shifts in any reportable theme and represents a genuine reputational gain that destination marketing has not yet fully captured. Rwanda leads the peer group on safety by **34.5 points**, the largest reportable thematic gap in the benchmark. Given that safety anxiety is a primary inhibitor for first-time Africa visitors, this is a conversion lever, not merely a reassurance point.

Cost and transport are the friction themes. Cost returns a net of just **13.9** across **36 mentions**, the lowest of all reportable themes, and its negativity has worsened within the period. Transport nets **19.4** but carries **25.0%** negative, and its negativity is also drifting upward — though that movement does not clear the reportable threshold for trend purposes. The voices in the corpus are not uniformly critical of Rwanda's ambitions: @sabomarov7279 (Nov 2021) argued that switching from French to English "paved the way for its later successes," situating Rwanda's development trajectory as a positive story — but such strategic framing sits alongside practical frustrations with price levels that surface repeatedly in the thematic coding. The combination of cost pressure and transport friction forms a coherent barrier narrative that, if unaddressed, will erode the conversion rate for the large pool of neutral and aspiring observers identified in the perception overview.

DATA NOTE
Water and electricity each fall below the 15-mention minimum threshold and are therefore excluded from headline findings, though both show worsening direction indicatively.

Voices behind the numbers

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions in this view. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

POSITIVE · @forcexjr1566 · Jul 2020 · 3,549 likes · score +0.90
“Dear citizens of Rwanda, keep at it! You guys are doing great! Cheers from Singapore.”

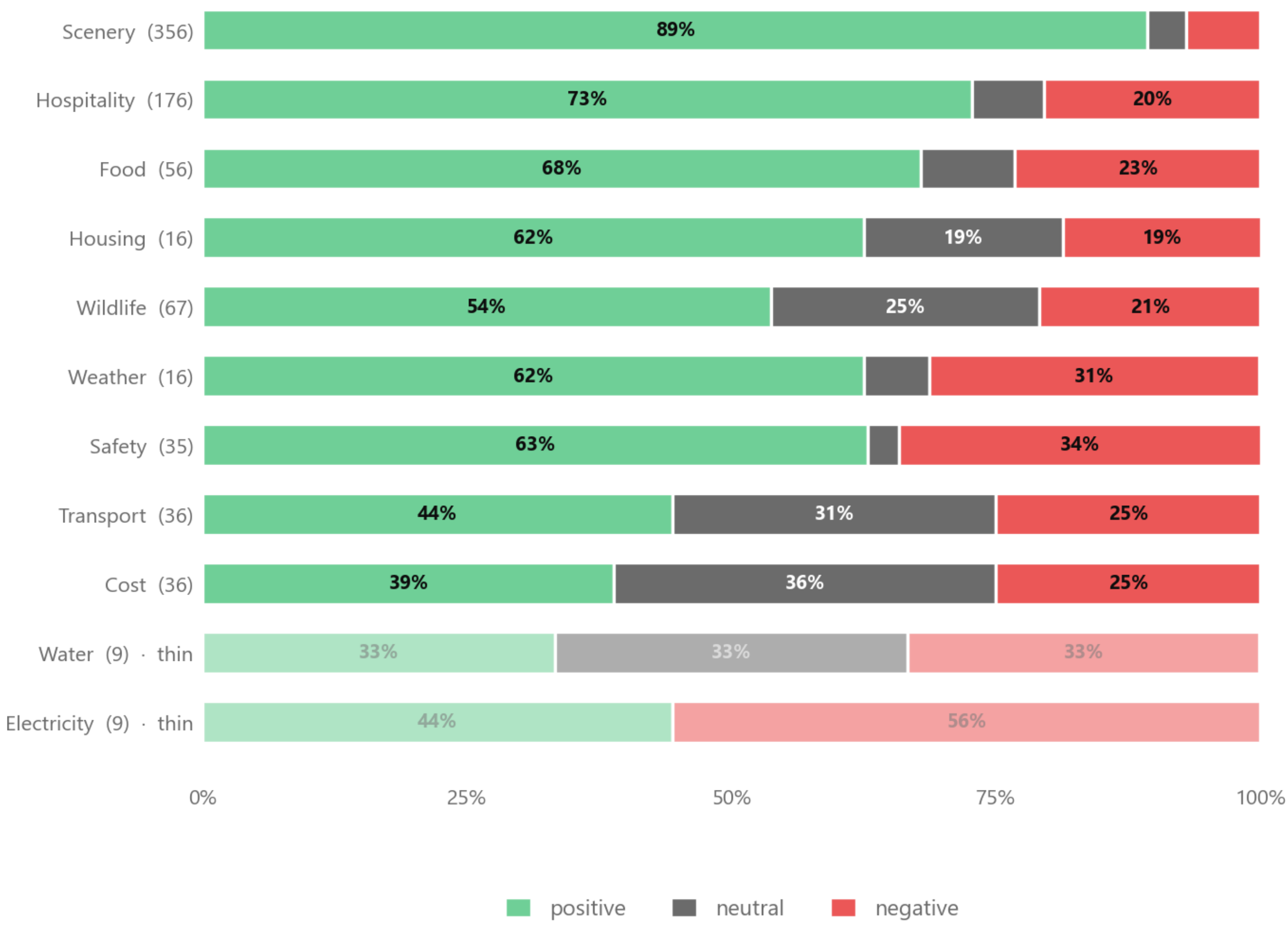
POSITIVE · @MrAlexkyra · Mar 2021 · 3,091 likes · score +0.29
“Rwanda's also the place where they manufacture Africa's first smartphone: Mara Phones and they also manufacture motorcycles. This is what I hope the future will be in Africa, instead of just being a source of raw materials for Europe, America and China, they'll do their own manufacturing and trade…”

NEGATIVE · @Wendoverproductions · Mar 2019 · 3,447 likes · score -0.30
“I know that this topic, like most geopolitics topics, has more potential than most to be contentious so I think it's extra important for you to know where the information comes from. Nothing said in this video is new and you can find all the sources at this link: https://goo.gl/5KDmvB Normally the…”

NEGATIVE · @sabomarov7279 · Nov 2021 · 1,424 likes · score -0.13
“There's a HUGE aspect that you missed in this video: abandoning French. France has always been in the way of African development, and has weaponised the French language to enforce its interests. By no longer using French and switching to English, Rwanda was able to integrate into the global economy…”

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

Only the **adventure traveller cohort** clears the 50-record threshold required for reportable analysis, with **79 records**, a **perception score of 66**, and a **net sentiment of 46.8**. Within that cohort, **62.0%** of records are positive and **15.2%** negative — a profile that is meaningfully below the all-visitor perception score of **70** and net sentiment of **54.3**. The gap suggests that adventure travellers — those most likely to be engaging with gorilla trekking, hiking, and remote terrain — encounter friction that the average visitor does not, plausibly around physical access, cost of specialised permits, and transport reliability to remote sites. The implication for product teams is that the adventure experience, while broadly positive, underdelivers relative to expectation and relative to Rwanda's own overall standing.

Because only one cohort is reportable, direct comparisons between segments cannot be drawn with analytical confidence. The luxury, budget, and business cohorts each fall well below the 50-record threshold, and their scores — while available in the data — cannot anchor segment-level findings or be ranked against the adventure cohort. What can be said is that the overall visitor base skews heavily toward unclassified visitors, with the four named segments together representing only **7.5%** of all classified records. This limits the granularity of targeting guidance that can be drawn from the current corpus and points to a data-collection gap that, if closed, would significantly strengthen the next iteration of this analysis. Tourism board messaging should currently be calibrated to the all-visitor average, with the adventure segment treated as a distinct, validated sub-audience warranting dedicated outreach on permit pricing and access logistics.

DATA NOTE
Only one visitor cohort — adventure — meets the 50-record threshold and is therefore the only segment whose findings can headline or anchor a recommendation. Luxury, budget, and business cohorts are indicative only and have not been compared against each other or against the adventure cohort.

DATA NOTE
The proportion of records that could not be classified into a segment is very high. A structured data-collection programme — for example, post-visit surveys or booking-source tagging — would significantly improve segment resolution in future reporting periods.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF VIEW	PERCEPTION	NET
Adventure	79	5.2%	66/100	+47
Budget · thin	15	1.0%	51/100	+13
Business · thin	11	0.7%	54/100	+18
Luxury · thin	10	0.7%	66/100	+60

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

Rwanda ranks **3rd out of 10 reportable peers** with a perception score of **70**, sitting **3 points behind the leader Tanzania (73)** and level with Ghana (70) and Senegal (70). The grouping at 70 is meaningful: Rwanda, Ghana, and Senegal are statistically clustered, and small thematic shifts could reorder the ranking. Rwanda's net sentiment of **54.3** is, however, the strongest of that trio — above Ghana's **51.7** and Senegal's **49.7** — indicating that while the headline scores are identical, Rwanda's positive-to-negative balance is the most favourable in the cluster. Against the lower end of the peer group, Rwanda holds a substantial structural advantage: South Africa scores **65**, Egypt **64**, Nigeria **62**, and Morocco **39**.

The thematic benchmarking is where Rwanda's competitive identity becomes sharpest. On **safety**, Rwanda leads the peer group by **34.5 points** — a gap that is both large and reportable. No other destination in this peer set commands that kind of safety premium, and it is being underused as a positioning tool given that Rwanda's own marketing tends to lead with wildlife and scenery. On **cost**, Rwanda leads peers by **32.9 points**, a figure that may surprise given the domestic perception of Rwanda as an expensive destination — the data suggest that by regional comparison, value-for-money sentiment is still relatively favourable, even as it worsens at the margins. On **hospitality**, the lead is **32.1 points** over the peer net, and on **transport** the gap is **18.9 points** ahead. These are all reportable advantages that translate directly into competitive messaging themes.

The one reportable area where peers hold a lead over Rwanda — though the gap does not clear the 10-point reportable threshold — is wildlife. Rwanda's wildlife net of **32.8** trails the peer average of **38.8**, a gap of **6.0 points** that falls just below the reporting floor and should be monitored rather than actioned. The likely driver is that Rwanda's wildlife conversation is dominated by gorilla encounters, a high-cost, high-commitment experience that generates more mixed sentiment than the broader safari mix available in Tanzania or Kenya. Diversifying the wildlife narrative — incorporating Akagera's plains game, for instance — may help close this gap in future periods without requiring product investment.

DATA NOTE
Cameroon falls below the 50-record threshold and has been excluded from peer comparisons throughout this section.

DATA NOTE

The wildlife gap between Rwanda and the peer average is 6.0 points, which does not meet the 10-point reportable threshold. It is noted for monitoring purposes only.

DATA NOTE
The scenery gap of 8.0 points in Rwanda's favour also falls below the 10-point reporting threshold and is not stated as a competitive claim.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50
Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

06 TRENDS & SIGNALS

The long-run arc of Rwanda's perception score is one of substantial improvement — rising from **56 in 2015** to a peak of **79 in 2018** — followed by a sustained, if gradual, decline to **66 in 2026**. The overall period direction is classified as improving given the net **10-point gain** from start to end, but the post-2018 trajectory is unambiguously one of retreat and is the dominant signal for planning purposes. The decline from 79 to 66 across eight years is not a statistical artefact — it is consistent across multiple years and reinforced by rising negativity rates in the same sub-period. Negative sentiment stood at **8.6%** in 2018 and has risen, with some year-to-year variation, to **17.9%** in 2026. That is effectively a doubling of the negative share from the period's best year to its most recent, and it demands structural attention rather than tactical messaging adjustment.

The most decisive thematic trend is **safety's dramatic improvement**: negative safety mentions fell from **62.5%** in the first half of the period to **10.5%** in the second — a swing of **52.0 points**, far exceeding any other movement in the corpus. This is a genuine signal of reputational rehabilitation and is the product of sustained governance, visible urban order, and positive international commentary on Rwanda's security environment. It is the clearest win the data contain, and it arrived quietly — without a corresponding peak in destination marketing. The counterweight is **cost**, where negative mentions rose by **13.9 points** across the period, and **food**, where they rose by **8.6 points**. Both are reportable movements and together they suggest that as Rwanda's international profile has risen, visitor expectations on value and culinary diversity have risen faster than the product has kept pace.

Scenery and hospitality — the two highest-volume themes — are each stable across the period split. Scenery's negativity changed by just **1.3 points** and hospitality improved marginally by **2.2 points**. Stability in a market's two strongest pillars is a structural asset: it means the positive core is not eroding even as peripheral themes shift. The strategic implication is that Rwanda's foundation is intact and the challenge is one of managing rising expectations at the friction points — cost, food, and to a lesser extent transport — rather than defending the core proposition.

DATA NOTE
The 2026 data point covers only the period up to June 2026 and so represents a partial year. The perception score of 66 and negative rate of 17.9% for 2026 should be treated as a mid-year reading that may shift by year-end.

DATA NOTE
The 2017 record count of 27 falls below the 50-record minimum threshold; the 2017 perception score of 65 is included in the trend narrative only as part of the directional arc, not as an anchor point for precise claims.

DATA NOTE
Transport movement of 9.0 points worsening does not clear the reportable threshold of 10 points for trend claims and is noted as indicative only.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)
Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

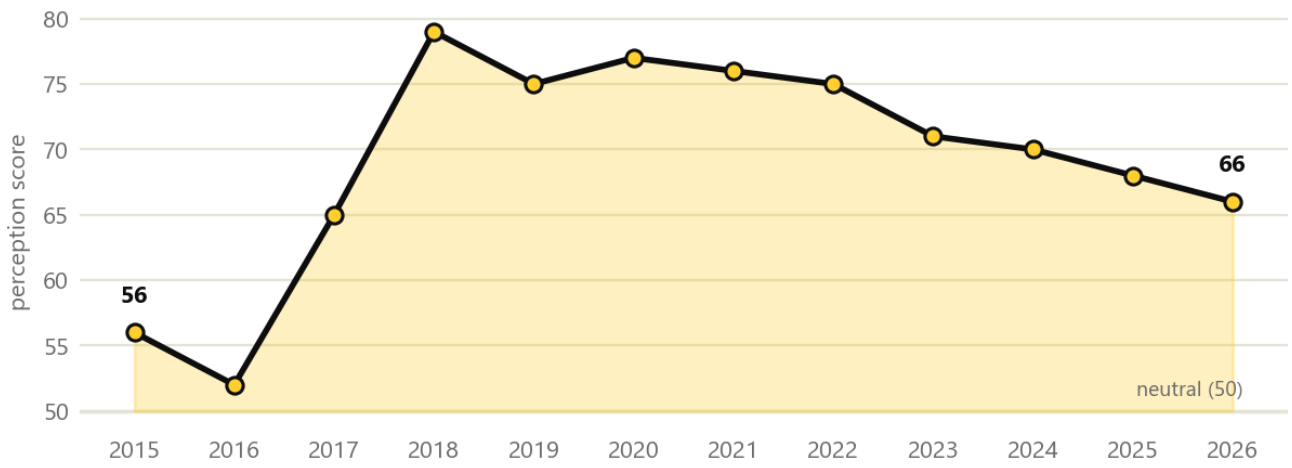
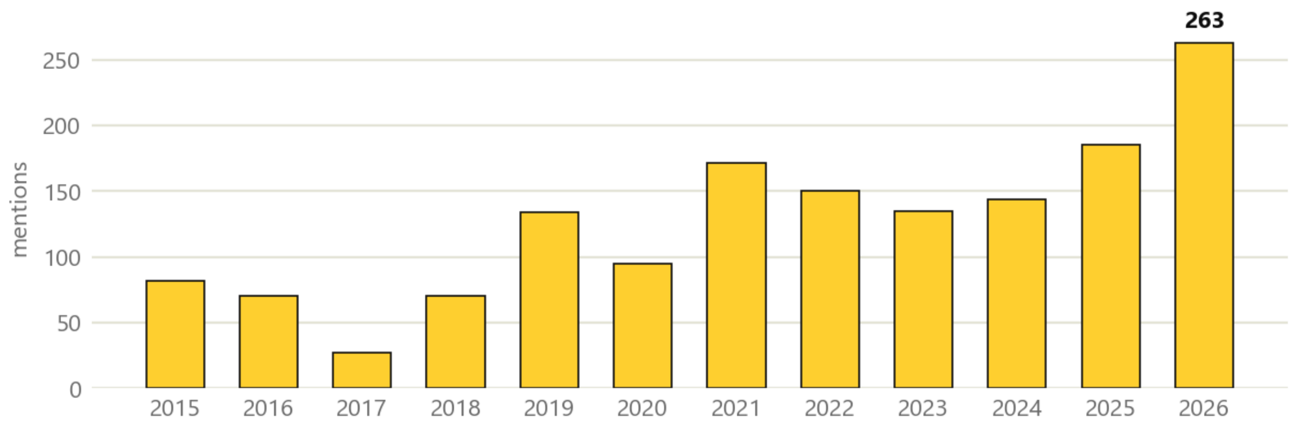


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)
Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The **safety rehabilitation signal** — a swing of **52.0 points** in negative safety mentions from the first to second half of the period — is the most actionable finding in this report and is currently the most underused. The tourism board should commission a dedicated safety-led campaign targeted at first-time Africa travellers, particularly from markets where security anxiety is the primary decision barrier. Rwanda's peer-group lead on safety of **34.5 points** is a verifiable, comparative claim that can be made with confidence in media and trade environments. The Rwanda Convention Bureau and international tour operators distributing to the European and North American mid-market should receive a specific briefing note quantifying this advantage, formatted for use in FAQs, booking conversations, and travel trade presentations.

The **worsening cost perception** — negative cost mentions rising by **13.9 points** across the period, the steepest confirmed thematic decline — requires a two-track response. In the short term, the Rwanda Development Board's marketing communications should move from aspirational pricing silence to active value framing: publishing transparent itinerary costing for mid-range travellers, contextualising gorilla-permit fees against the conservation outcome, and surfacing affordable itinerary options in digital channels. In the medium term, product teams should work with accommodation operators on entry-level certified lodge and guesthouse standards so that the value narrative is grounded in product, not just messaging. The adventure traveller segment — the only statistically validated cohort, with a perception score of **66** against a whole-market score of **70** — is the primary audience for this intervention, since adventure visitors are most exposed to permit and logistics costs.

Food negativity worsening by 8.6 points across the period is a friction signal that destination stakeholders can address without large capital expenditure. The Rwanda Tourism Board should partner with Kigali's culinary community and regional hospitality training providers to develop a "Taste of Rwanda" narrative — one that positions local cuisine as an experience rather than a utility stop. This should be embedded in pre-trip content distributed through the digital channels that currently lead with scenery: travellers arriving with curiosity about food, not just expectations of inadequacy, are markedly less likely to generate negative food reviews. Tour operators building itineraries for the European and North American market should be provided with a curated list of culinary experiences that can be embedded in existing gorilla and scenery itineraries with minimal structural change.

The **post-2018 score decline** — from a peak perception score of **79** to **66** in 2026, with the negative share roughly doubling from **8.6%** to **17.9%** — is a long-run structural signal that warrants a formal perception recovery programme rather than incremental tactical adjustments. The tourism board director should establish a quarterly tracking cadence against the themes identified here as worsening — cost and food — with threshold-based escalation triggers linked to the negativity rates. Concurrently, the large proportion of unclassified visitor records (representing the majority of the corpus) should prompt an investment in structured post-visit data collection — segment-tagged surveys, booking source attribution, or partnership with online travel agencies — that would allow future reports to disaggregate findings by luxury, business, and budget travellers and enable genuinely segment-specific targeting in ways the current evidence base cannot yet support.

DATA NOTE
Recommendations referencing the adventure segment are grounded in the only cohort that clears the 50-record threshold. Budget, business, and luxury segment recommendations cannot be drawn from the current evidence base and have been deferred pending improved data collection.

DATA NOTE

> The cost improvement recommendation references Rwanda's peer-group advantage of 32.9 points; this figure reflects the gap at the current snapshot and should be re-evaluated if the worsening trend continues.

08 METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	Rwanda
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all
Relevant records only	yes
Period	February 2015 – June 2026
Records	1,526
Generated	19 Aug 2026 12:31 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; every figure verified against the computed data.

Evidence base: 1,377 YouTube comments, 149 YouTube transcript segments. 88% of records were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.